Match the goal to the solution - complete text version

A useful recommendation starts with the customer’s goal and the evidence about its existing systems. In this activity, identify the benefit each customer wants, then choose a response supported by the facts. The suitable approach may be an on-premises improvement, cloud services or a hybrid combination. For each scenario, choose the business benefit that best matches the stated goal. Then choose what you would recommend. A smaller upfront payment does not prove a lower total cost. If a choice is not right, the feedback explains why and you can try again. Finally, match four changed goals to benefits. The companies are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 15 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. Read each scenario, choose the business benefit that best supports the goal, then choose the sentence you would say to the customer. Read the feedback for every option and compare it with your choices. If you chose differently, work out why before moving on. At the end, match the four changed goals to benefits.

The four business benefits

Four benefits customers may seek. A goal identifies what to investigate; it does not establish which technology will deliver the best result.

- Cost management: Manage spending over the period the business needs the system. On-premises may require more upfront capital, while cloud introduces continuing fees. Existing hardware, expertise, utilisation and future operating costs determine which option offers better value.
- Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits.
- Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner.
- Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements.

Scenario 1 of 4: Sto Lat Select

Sto Lat Select sells home and wellness products online. It owns usable servers, runs supported software and has experienced technical staff. Tests show that a modest local network upgrade will resolve slow checkout during promotions. A comparison over the agreed planning period finds this upgrade costs less than migration and continuing cloud charges, with no additional cloud benefit identified. Leadership wants reliable checkout while controlling future spending.

A. Which business benefit best matches the goal?

- Cost management - Best fit. Feedback: That matches the spending goal. The evidence here favours the local upgrade: existing equipment and expertise remain useful, and the comparison includes future operating costs. A cloud move has not shown enough additional value.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Demand changes during promotions, but testing has identified a local network problem and a suitable fix. The stated priority is controlling spending while restoring reliable checkout.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. There is no new-product launch to accelerate. The priority is reliable checkout and future spending.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The scenario does not describe expansion into new markets. Focus on the cost and checkout evidence.

What gave it away: Leadership wants reliable checkout while controlling future spending.

B. What would you recommend?

Now choose the recommendation you would explain to this customer.

- “The assessment supports upgrading your local connection and keeping the servers and software you already run. It meets the expected need at lower future cost, so we have no reason to recommend a cloud migration.” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It recommends the on-premises fix supported by the technical and cost assessment, rather than introducing an unnecessary cloud service.
- “A cloud service has a smaller initial payment, so I recommend moving even though the local upgrade costs less over the comparison period.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A smaller initial payment does not establish better value. The comparison favours the local upgrade and identifies no additional cloud benefit.
- “I recommend a hybrid setup so you have some cloud capacity, even though the local upgrade already meets the expected need.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A hybrid setup also needs a reason. Adding cloud capacity and management work without a supported need would not serve this customer.

Scenario 2 of 4: Laconia Energy Systems

Laconia Energy Systems models energy use for engineering projects. Its existing equipment and staff handle everyday work well, but occasional projects need much more processing capacity for a short period. A technical trial confirms that those extra analysis jobs can run in cloud services connected to the local systems. The cost assessment favours temporary cloud capacity over buying extra servers that would be idle between projects; moving all existing work would add unnecessary migration costs. Leadership wants capacity to expand and contract with project demand.

A. Which business benefit best matches the goal?

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost evidence helps select the arrangement, but the stated goal is capacity that changes with project demand. Cost is not the main benefit being matched here.
- Flexibility - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The tested hybrid arrangement keeps everyday work on the existing systems and adds cloud capacity for temporary analysis jobs. The application, connection and cost evidence support that choice.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can speed up development cycles, but Laconia’s need is not launch speed.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud services can extend global access, but this scenario is about fluctuating workloads.

What gave it away: Leadership wants capacity to expand and contract with project demand.

B. What would you recommend?

Now choose the recommendation you would explain to this customer.

- “Replace the existing systems with cloud services because flexibility requires moving all your work away from local equipment.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The trial shows that only the extra analysis jobs need cloud capacity. Full migration adds costs without an identified benefit for the everyday work.
- “Keep everyday work on the systems your team already runs, and use the tested cloud connection for temporary analysis jobs. That gives you extra capacity when projects need it without replacing the whole setup.” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. This hybrid recommendation follows the trial and cost assessment, retains useful equipment and expertise, and uses cloud capacity for a specific need.
- “Buy enough local servers for the largest possible project so you will not need to adjust capacity between projects.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This does not match the goal of expanding and contracting capacity. In this case the assessment favours temporary cloud capacity over extra servers idle between projects.

Scenario 3 of 4: Solitude Innovations

Solitude Innovations is a young technology company developing analytics tools for startup clients. The company is preparing to release a new product that will let early-stage businesses forecast market trends more accurately. The engineering team is under pressure to deliver quickly to stay ahead of competitors, and building and testing the product internally could take months, delaying the launch and increasing costs. The product manager wants to shorten the development timeline and deploy faster without compromising performance or security, and leadership is determined to reach the market before larger competitors introduce similar solutions.

A. Which business benefit best matches the goal?

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost needs checking for any recommendation, but the stated priority in this scenario is a different benefit.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud supports flexibility, but the emphasis here is on launching sooner.
- Faster time-to-market - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can shorten time to market by providing ready-made development and test environments, so teams spend less time setting up infrastructure and can focus sooner on building and testing.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud enables delivery to other countries, but that is not Solitude Innovations' focus.

What gave it away: The product manager wants to shorten the development timeline and deploy faster, and leadership is determined to reach the market before larger competitors introduce similar solutions.

B. What would you recommend?

Now choose the recommendation you would explain to this customer.

- "You will launch before every competitor." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud tools may reduce setup work, but they do not guarantee a launch date or a lead over competitors.
- "We provide a fully managed deployment pipeline with container orchestration." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is technology language. The product manager's goal is a shorter timeline, so say what changes in time.
- "Cloud tools can give your team ready-made environments for building and testing, so they spend less time setting up and can move the product forward sooner." - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It links ready-made environments to a shorter timeline without promising a market outcome.

Scenario 4 of 4: Ashbourne Global

Ashbourne Global is a mid-sized corporate-training firm that provides leadership-development programmes to international organisations. After several successful partnerships in one region, new clients from Europe and Asia have expressed interest in accessing its digital learning platform. Hosting and delivering the same experience to clients around the world would mean expanding its technology infrastructure and support teams across multiple time zones. The executive team wants to reach new global markets quickly while keeping performance, data security and customer satisfaction consistent, without establishing physical offices in each country.

A. Which business benefit best matches the goal?

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost needs checking for any recommendation, but the stated priority in this scenario is a different benefit.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud offers flexibility for changing workloads, but this scenario is about serving clients in other countries.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can speed up launches, but Ashbourne's challenge is geographic, not development speed.
- Global reach - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can help a business reach customers in more regions without building infrastructure in each country, but the right services, regions, connectivity, data needs and security responsibilities still need checking.

What gave it away: The executive team wants to reach new global markets quickly while keeping performance, data security and customer satisfaction consistent, without establishing physical offices in each country.

B. What would you recommend?

Now choose the recommendation you would explain to this customer.

- "We provide multi-region points of presence with global load balancing." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is technical language. Their goal is reaching clients in new countries without opening offices, so say that.
- "Clients everywhere will get identical speed and zero downtime." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This promises more than you can support. Describe what the cloud makes possible and avoid absolute guarantees.
- "A cloud provider with services in multiple regions can help you serve customers in Europe and Asia from the same platform without opening offices or building infrastructure in each country, if that setup meets your data and connectivity needs." - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It ties the global network to their goal and answers the concern about offices and infrastructure.

The goal changes

Priorities can change. Identify which business benefit each new goal concerns. This is not enough information to choose a hosting arrangement; any recommendation still needs a comparison of suitable options.

Changed goal 1 of 4

Sto Lat Select now wants to open its online store to shoppers in other countries.

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost management: Manage spending over the period the business needs the system. On-premises may require more upfront capital, while cloud introduces continuing fees. Existing hardware, expertise, utilisation and future operating costs determine which option offers better value. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.
- Global reach - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements.

Changed goal 2 of 4

Laconia Energy Systems now says its main worry is the large upfront cost of buying hardware for next year’s projects.

- Cost management - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Cost management: Manage spending over the period the business needs the system. On-premises may require more upfront capital, while cloud introduces continuing fees. Existing hardware, expertise, utilisation and future operating costs determine which option offers better value.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility means adding or removing resources on demand. This goal is about avoiding a large upfront purchase.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about avoiding large upfront spending.

- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about avoiding large upfront spending.

Changed goal 3 of 4

Solitude Innovations now wants its next feature built and live before a competitor’s release.

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost management: Manage spending over the period the business needs the system. On-premises may require more upfront capital, while cloud introduces continuing fees. Existing hardware, expertise, utilisation and future operating costs determine which option offers better value. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.
- Faster time-to-market - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.

Changed goal 4 of 4

Ashbourne Global now needs its platform to cope with a sudden rush when a big client signs up, then settle back.

- Cost management - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Spending matters, but the goal here is capacity that rises and falls with demand.
- Flexibility - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about adding capacity for a short period and releasing it afterwards.

- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about adding capacity for a short period and releasing it afterwards.

Reflect and save

You matched four business goals and selected recommendations supported by the facts: an on-premises improvement, a hybrid arrangement and appropriate uses of cloud services.

- Sto Lat Select: Cost management.
- Laconia Energy Systems: Flexibility.
- Solitude Innovations: Faster time-to-market.
- Ashbourne Global: Global reach.

Choose one recommendation. Explain the evidence that supports it and what change in the customer’s needs or costs could make you reconsider. (optional) In the interactive version, Save my summary downloads your summary as a text file. Reflection is optional, and the summary can be saved without it. A suitable recommendation follows the customer’s needs and evidence. Keeping or improving on-premises systems is a valid outcome; cloud and hybrid choices need to justify their additional costs and work.

Finish and return

Activity complete — well done! You have matched four customers and their changed goals to business benefits. Reflection and saving a summary are optional. Return to FutureLearn and mark this step complete there. This activity does not update your FutureLearn completion status.